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The Rebel's Dilemma

Mark Irving Lichbach

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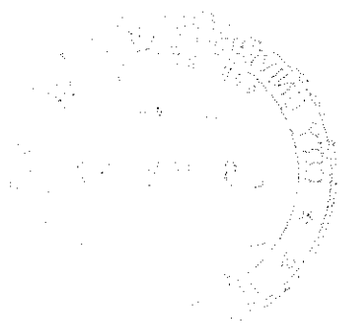
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For Dad, who would have been proud

I dedicate this book to my father, Joseph Lichbach, who missed the *simcha* of Sammi Jo's birth. He now misses yet another *simcha*. My mother, my sister, and I miss him in ways that words cannot express. Sammi Jo will miss him in ways that she can never know.

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CHAPTER 1

The Problem Defined

This chapter defines the book's *problematique*. I offer an example of collective dissent (sect. 1.1) and show how the Deprived Actor (DA, sect. 1.2) research program tackles the problem. Attention then shifts to the Collective Action (CA, sect. 1.3) research program for a consideration of how applied theorists of conflict (sect. 1.4) and pure theorists of CA (sect. 1.5) have reacted to CA ideas.

1.1. An Example

To fix ideas, consider the following thought experiment. Jane Smith, an undergraduate at the University of Colorado, strongly supports the principle of diversity in employment. She also believes reports claiming that academic tenuring practices for minorities and women at the university have been discriminatory. Jane thus advocates a vigorous affirmative action program, one with quotas in various job categories for certain protected classes. The Cause, a campus civil rights organization, holds similar beliefs and advocates a similar program. Moreover, it has just announced that it plans to picket The Administration next Monday morning, starting at 9:00 A.M, and has called for volunteers. Question: will Jane join the demonstration, or will she wish the picketers well and stay home?

Students of conflict seek to explain Jane's (non)participation in the protest demonstration in terms of both general premises about participation in collective dissent and conditions unique to Jane's situation. In other words, students of conflict have studied such specific situations by posing a more general question: why do individuals participate in collective dissent? By *collective* is meant that individuals participate in some group activity. By *dissent* is meant that the individuals' objectives are to change government institutions, policies and/or personnel. Dissent also involves means that are somewhat unconventional. Participants go beyond voting and interest group activities; that is, they typically threaten and/or employ physical coercion and/or other illegal activities. The boundaries of this concept have always been ill defined (Zimmermann 1983, chap. 2; Taylor and Jodice 1983, chap. 2). The core political behaviors under scrutiny are clearer, however. They

consist of the negative cases to theories of social order mentioned in the preface (page xi). [1]

The purpose of this book is to explore the implications of the CA research program for the major puzzles and problems of the causes, courses, and consequences of collective dissent. I also intend to evaluate, in both Lakatos's (1970) and Popper's (1968) senses, how well the CA research program explains these major riddles in conflict studies. The remainder of this chapter elaborates upon my purposes.

1.2. The Deprived Actor Research Program

The DA research program provides the traditional answer to the question of whether Jane will participate in the demonstration. This approach, whose foremost proponent is Ted Gurr (1970), maintains that deprivation produces discontent and that discontent, in turn, produces dissent. Collective dissent is therefore ultimately caused by people's preferences, beliefs, and attitudes towards personal deprivations.

DA theories have suggested many specific psychological processes (both cognitive and emotional) that turn deprivations, such as the discrimination perceived by Jane, into dissent. Hence, Jane may join the demonstration because she experiences any one or more of the following: frustration over wants and necessities which she cannot satisfy; a lack of just deserts, or a discrepancy between what she felt entitled to and what she actually got; a lack of equity and distributive justice because her inputs into the system have far exceeded her outputs from it; relative deprivation vis-a-vis more advantaged groups; alienation from government and a belief that the government is illegitimate because of policy dissatisfaction and lack of system responsiveness; lack of support for government due to political cynicism and the absence of political trust; class or racial consciousness; or radicalism and the identification with dissident groups that promise to end the deprivations (Zimmermann 1983, chap. 4). Whichever specific psychological processes are involved, DA theorists expect that deprivations generate grievances about patterns of authority; that grievances generate identification with similarly deprived actors; and that these deprivations, grievances, and identifications generate the anger that eventually produces behavioral dissent.

DA theorists such as Gurr (1970) therefore interpret the thought experiment posed earlier as follows: if the job discrimination is severe, Jane's grievances will be profound, her sympathies for The Cause and its concerns will be deep, and she will become angry enough to join the demonstration.

While one might question the specific psychological processes involved, the general perspective offered by the DA approach seems beyond dispute. It is obvious, is it not, that deprived people become frustrated, that

frustrated people become angry, and that angry people often strike out at those responsible for their frustrations?

1.3. The Collective Action Research Program

The challenge to the truisms of DA theories was first formalized in Mancur Olson's (1965) seminal work, *The Logic of Collective Action.* The most widely cited application of Olson's argument to protest is Gordon Tullock's (1971a) "The Paradox of Revolution." Both works challenge the assumptions made by DA theories about a rebel's motivation, and consequently dispute the conclusion that individual deprivation eventually leads to collective dissent. I call this approach the CA research program.

To understand the CA alternative to DA theories, reconsider Jane's problem. Jane and all of The Cause's sympathizers may choose to Demonstrate (D) or to Stay Home (S). Suppose Jane ponders the possible outcomes of her two choices, given what she expects Everyone Else to do. Outcomes may be represented in the 2x2 matrix shown in Exhibit 1.

		Everyone Else's Choices: Demonstrate	Everyone Else's Choices: Stay Home
Jane's Choices	Demonstrate	Benefits = Diversity Costs = Time Lost	Benefits = 0 Costs = Time Lost
	Stay Home	Benefits = Diversity Costs = 0	Benefits = 0 Costs = 0

Exhibit 1. Jane's Dilemma

If *D* represents "Demonstrate" and *S* represents "Stay Home," the strategy combination "Jane chooses to Demonstrate (*D*) while Everyone Else chooses to Stay Home (*S*)" is denoted (*D,S*).

The matrix indicates that Jane must weigh four logically possible outcomes.

(D,D). Jane chooses to Demonstrate and Everyone Else also chooses to Demonstrate. If all of its sympathizers choose to Demonstrate, The Cause will be politically powerful. Jane thus assumes that The Administration will end job discrimination, provide additional academic positions for minorities, and uphold the principle of diversity. However, Jane must bear a personal cost. She has spent her valuable time at the demonstration.

(S,D). Jane chooses to Stay Home but Everyone Else chooses to Demonstrate. If all of its sympathizers *except* Jane choose to Demonstrate, The Cause's loss of strength is imperceptible. Jane thus continues to assume that

The Administration will provide additional academic jobs for minorities and uphold the important principle of diversity. However, Jane now bears no personal cost.

(S,S). Jane chooses to Stay Home and Everyone Else also chooses to Stay Home. The Cause is now powerless. Jane thus assumes that The Administration will provide no additional jobs for minorities. However, Jane bears no personal cost.

(D,S). Jane chooses to Demonstrate but Everyone Else chooses to Stay Home. The Cause is now powerless *except* for Jane, who now assumes that The Administration will provide no additional jobs for minorities. Much to her dismay, moreover, Jane must bear a personal cost that arises from the time she has spent demonstrating. (The campus police will not react kindly to Jane's solo attempt to picket the dean's office; they are much kinder and gentler when hundreds of students block the office.)

Now the key question: given the assumptions made in the above model of CA, will rational Jane participate in the demonstration? The answer comes in two parts.

Consider a normative analysis of the situation. Jane and Everyone Else believe that they are better off if all Demonstrate rather than all Stay Home. Mutual cooperation is in the interest of every member of The Cause, including Jane.

Now consider a positive analysis of the situation. Everyone Else has two choices. First, suppose Everyone Else Demonstrates. Jane then prefers to Stay Home rather than to Demonstrate. The benefits of diversity will come regardless of whether she protests, and protest is, after all, costly. Second, suppose Everyone Else Stays Home. Jane still prefers to Stay Home, rather than to Demonstrate. The benefits of diversity are unavailable, regardless of whether she protests, and protest is, once again, costly. In sum, Jane's beliefs about Everyone Else's choice is irrelevant. She always chooses to Stay Home. Since a similar analysis holds for each of The Cause's sympathizers, all will Stay Home. No one will Demonstrate. The Administration is safe, and the dean can conduct business as usual.

Accordingly, rebels like Jane face what has been called a Prisoner's Dilemma (PD). The normative and positive analyses of their situation conflict. Mutual cooperation (i.e., all choose to Demonstrate) is better for Jane and Everyone Else than mutual noncooperation (i.e., all choose to Stay Home). However, individualistically rational behavior produces mutual noncooperation.

Jane's predicament has also been called a public goods (PG) problem. The costs of participation are high and involve time, money, and the risk of injury. The benefit of participation, if the group is successful, is a PG that can be enjoyed by anyone, regardless of his or her (non)participation.[2] Even if she does not protest, Jane benefits from ending job discrimination, the provision of additional academic jobs for minorities, and the principle of diversity. Hence, each of The Cause's sympathizers wants to free ride on the contributions of others; that is, everyone hopes that someone else will absorb the costs, yet everyone wishes to share in the benefits.

In sum, all of the cards seem stacked against large-scale protests and rebellions. On the benefit side: (1) a successful outcome to a revolt is a low-probability event, and hence, the revolt is a risky undertaking; (2) a successful outcome to a revolt is almost independent of any one individual's participation; (3) the benefits of a successful revolt are also independent of any one individual's participation. On the cost side: (1) rebels are typically interested in many social causes; (2) rebels have many personal demands on their time that have priority — their opportunity costs include, for example, forgone wages; (3) participation is often quite costly and dangerous since governments maim or murder their enemies. Thus, rebels confront possibly disastrous private costs and uncertain public benefits. Moreover, the benefits provide no incentive to act and the costs provide every incentive not to act. Rebels have everything to gain and nothing to lose by staying home. Unless this CA problem is somehow overcome, rational people will never rebel — rebellions, that is, require irrationality.[3] I call the general tragedy confronting all participants in CA the Cooperator's Dilemma (Lichbach forthcoming). I call the specific tragedy confronting dissidents the Rebel's Dilemma.

What has been the reaction to Olson's ideas? The next two sections position my study in the collective action and collective dissent literatures.

1.4. The Reaction to Olson: Applied Students of Collective Dissent

Students of conflict have been intrigued by Olson's reasoning and have attempted to wed CA ideas and conflict studies. The marriage brokers were sociologists, political scientists, and economists.

Sociologists and political scientists have utilized the general rational actor aspect of Olson's approach. Many (Zimmermann 1983, 603–4, fn. 47) define political violence in terms of rational action. Thus, some definitions of political violence emphasize its bargaining aspects: "*acts of disruption, destruction, injury whose purpose, choice of targets or victims, surrounding circumstances, implementation, and/or effects have political significance, that is, tend to modify the behavior of others in a bargaining situation that has consequences for the social system*" (Nieburg 1969, 13, emphasis in original). Such reasoning has also influenced explanations of rebel's motivations; nonelites, many argue, also calculate costs and benefits and pursue rational political action (Armstrong 1976, 394). Tarrow (1989, 8, 16), for one, suggests that people protest when other ways of achieving their interests and values are less productive or when the gains from protest outweigh the costs. Finally, rational actor reasoning has influenced general theories of

conflict. Widely cited efforts by sociologists include Oberschall (1973), Zald and McCarthy (1990), Korpi (1974), Gamson (1990), Tilly (1978), and Blalock (1989).

Some sociologists and political scientists have also confronted CA theories more directly. Charles Tilly (1978), among others, rejects the core CA assumption of individual rationality (that is, a person participates in collective dissent when his or her individual benefits exceed the individual costs) and posits instead collective rationality. As Gamson (1990, 138) puts it, "The collective goals of political actors rather than the personal goals of members are assumed to be the relevant part of an explanation of political behavior." Tilly thus assumes that a person will participate in collective dissent when his or her group's benefits exceed the group's costs. Tilly's inquiry is therefore guided by the central Marxian question: "How and why do groups in society come into conflict over valued conditions and positions?" It is less influenced by the central CA question: "Why do rational people rebel?" Tilly, in short, does not explain how the Rebel's Dilemma is solved. Rather than using the CA research program, he develops an alternative to it. Tilly's model of group conflict thus combines rational actor theory and class theory, or perhaps as he would put it, Adam Smith and Karl Marx. Gamson (1990) and Zald and McCarthy (1990) proceed similarly, combining a rational actor perspective with organizational theory.

Thus, studies by sociologists and political scientists did acknowledge the rebel's PG–PD problem. But Tilly, Gamson, and others vigorously disputed the assumptions behind CA theories, and thus never took the Rebel's Dilemma seriously. They merely borrowed one or two of its key insights (e.g., selective incentives, entrepreneurs) and for inspiration looked elsewhere (e.g., Marxist theory, organizational theory).

With their half-hearted attitude toward the CA approach, the efforts by sociologists and political scientists had two negative consequences for conflict studies. First, the bulk of the ideas available in the CA research program were ignored. Sociologists and political scientists never fully exploited the potential of CA theories for explaining domestic political conflict. As Marwell and Oliver (1984, 3, emphasis in original) put it, "Although Olson's work has thus had a general impact on social movement theory, *most* of his analysis is only marginally considered in that literature." For example, no sociologist or political scientist has ever examined the full range of post-Olson solutions to the free-rider problem that have appeared in CA studies.

Second, the bulk of the implications of CA thought for collective dissent have been unexplored. Neither Gamson, Tilly, nor any of their followers ever made much heuristic use of the theory. Marwell and Oliver's (1984, 4) comments are, again, to the point:

> Despite near universal recognition by this decade's scholars of social movements of the importance of collective action theory, little systematic work has been done to link collective action theory to social movements theory. Most social movements scholars simply cite Olson concerning the problematic of collective action. Only a few . . . have developed formal models for particular collective action situations and have discussed their implications for certain problems of mobilization.

In short, sociologists and political scientists have never systematically developed the implications of the CA approach for conflict studies. The contrast with Gurr's (1970) work is stark. Whereas he attempted to derive propositions from DA assumptions that integrated numerous middle-level hypotheses and stylized facts about domestic political conflict, Tilly never ventured that far into conflict studies.[4]

Where do the economists stand in these matters? Several economists and their followers in political science and sociology have offered models of collective dissent based on rational actor reasoning (Lichbach 1992, 345–47). Some have argued and/or modeled how externalities and PGs (Olson 1969), positional or status goods (Shubik 1971), and the zero-sum tradeoff along a contract curve (Hirshleifer 1987) produce conflict. There are utility maximization models of the decision calculus of regimes (Lichbach 1984; Wintrobe 1990) and of oppositions (Lichbach 1987). And some have proposed game theoretic models of conflict over economic inequality (Lichbach 1990), the interaction between states and oppositions (Sandler, Tschirhart, and Cauley 1983), and the emergence of consociational institutions to contain ethnic conflict (Tsebelis 1990, chap. 6). None of these efforts confront Olson's Problem, however. Rational choice models, though they are, they do not address the Rebel's Dilemma.

Some economists and their followers in political science and sociology have offered models to capture Olson's insights (Lichbach 1992, 345–47). Some expected utility models formulate a dissident's choice as a binary one: people choose dissent over nondissident activities when the expected utility of the former is greater than the expected utility of the latter. This framework has been applied to rebellion by Tullock (1971a), DeNardo (1985, 52–54), Muller and Opp (1986), and Opp (1989). Other expected utility models formulate a dissident's choice as a continuous one: rebels choose a continuous level of contributions (e.g., time spent) so as to maximize their expected utility. This framework has been applied to international terrorism (Sandler and Scott 1987), hijacking of U.S. aircraft (Landes 1978), riots (Chalmers and Shelton 1975; Coleman 1978; Mason 1984), government violence (Frohlich and Oppenheimer 1973), and revolution (Mueller 1989, 173–75). PD models (e.g., Buchanan 1979) also exist.

Unlike the previously cited studies, these works by economists and their followers do take the rebel's PG–PD problem seriously.[5] Unless the free rider problem is overcome (e.g., by selective incentives), they suggest that a rational person will ordinarily not rebel. Despite these strengths, however, such studies still manifest some of the limitations found in the sociological studies cited above. First, most ideas from CA theories have not been explored — no economist has ever examined the full range of post-Olson solutions to the free rider problem. Second, many of these authors were either unfamiliar with or unconcerned about the substantive and theoretical work done in the field of conflict studies. Economists have generally made no attempt to address the major puzzles and problems in that field. The bulk of the implications of the CA research program for collective dissent, again, went unexplored.

In sum, most sociologists, political scientists, and economists who have studied conflict have ignored much of Olson and his follower's work, preferring instead to examine general rational actor arguments, rather than the specific Rebel's Dilemma. Those who apply Olson's insights do so in limited ways: they neither use all that much of the theory nor explore all that much of the application. Thus, sociologists and political scientists have mostly ignored the CA research program (the theory), while economists have mostly ignored conflict studies (the substance).

The marriage between the CA research program and conflict studies, in short, has largely failed. Two sympathetic sociologists, Marwell and Oliver (1984, 2) comment that

> in Olson's (1965) analysis of the problem of collective action many social scientists found a basis for reinterpreting social movements. Incorporation of this new perspective, however, has been unsystematic and mostly confined to generalities. Everyone assumes that collective action and social movements have a close relationship, but the nature of that relationship remains ill-defined.

Economists generally agree with such skeptical appraisals of what their theories have brought to the field of conflict studies. A presumably sympathetic economist, Mueller (1989, 175), observes that "although the rational behavior approach to revolutionary activity gives some insights into why revolutions occur, it does not generate a rich harvest of testable implications." Another sympathetically inclined economist, Eggertsson (1990, 73–74), suggests that Gordon Tullock's (1971) economic theory of revolution is a good illustration of the limits of the purely economic approach when applied to group behavior in situations where there are incentives for free riding."

Even Olson (1965, 161–62), alas, apparently believes that participation in "mass movements" is better explained by social psychological theories

and collective behavior theories than by his own approach. But he waffles on the point. On the one hand, he is confident about the scope of his theory. He refers (1965, 162) to mass movements "which, incidentally, are usually not very massive," and maintains (1965, 162, fn. 97) that his theory fits the amoral familism culture discovered by Banfield (1958). He (1965, 161, fn. 94) goes so far as to suggest that his theory could explain utopian mass movements: "Even large groups that work for a utopia could have a reason for acting as a group, even in terms of the theory offered here . . . If the benefit that would come from establishing a utopia is infinite, it could be rational even for the member of a large group to contribute voluntarily to the achievement of the group goal (the utopia)." However, he is clearly uncomfortable in pushing this last point: "It is not clear that this is the best way of theorizing about either utopian or religious groups" (Olson 1965, 162, fn. 94). He is, ironically, quick to express confidence that an alternative approach to collective dissent, the one that I have called DA theories, would work where his own approach fails:

> Where nonrational or irrational behavior is the basis for a lobby, it would perhaps be better to turn to psychology or social psychology than to economics for a relevant theory . . . The adherents of "mass movements" are usually explained in terms of their "alienation" from society. This alienation produces a psychological disturbance or disequilibrium. The support for "mass movements" can accordingly be explained mainly in psychological terms, though the psychological disturbances are in turn related to various characteristics of the social structure. A fanatic devotion to an ideology or leader is common in mass movements, and many of these movements are often said to be on the "lunatic fringe." This sort of lobby is more common in periods of revolution and upheaval, and in unstable countries, than it is for stable, well-ordered, and apathetic societies that have seen the "end of ideology." (Olson 1965, 161–62)

Olson (1990, 1991a,1991b,1991c, 1991d) subsequently regained confidence in his theory and produced a series of analyses of protest and rebellion that make very imaginative use of his seminal insights.[6]

1.5. The Reaction to Olson: Pure Theorists of Collective Action

While students of conflict were meeting Olson's ideas with disinterest, disappointment, and disillusion, CA theorists were busily elaborating Olson's basic argument. It is to this happier story that I now turn.

The obvious challenge to Olson is that he is simply wrong: people quite often rebel, sometimes in very large numbers. CA theorists tackle this prob-

lem by considering the two logically possible categories of people. There are, first, those with grievances who do not rebel. By far the larger category, this group represents at least ninety-five percent of aggrieved people, at least ninety-five percent of the time, in at least ninety-five percent of the places. In short, potential rebels mostly do not rebel, even when it would be in every rebel's interest to do so. This category, which critics tend to ignore, is consistent with Olson's ideas. There are, second, those who do rebel. While this is by far the smaller category, one cannot ignore the fact that some people at some times in some places are able to overcome the Rebel's Dilemma and rebel. This is referred to as the *paradox* or *puzzle* of CA.

Thus, the canonical conclusion drawn from the prototypical case must be taken seriously. The central CA question is, How *is* the Rebel's Dilemma solved? Put otherwise, under what circumstances will cooperation emerge? What induces an individual to make a sacrifice to obtain a PG? And not only CA theorists but also many other researchers in conflict studies raise a similar question. From their various theoretical and practical perspectives, DA theorists,[7] Marxists,[8] Weberians,[9] and agenda setters[10] all seek the causes of political unity. All want to determine what factors influence the ability of different groups to form and people to come together in defense of their common economic, social, and political interests.

CA theorists of course proceed in their own distinctive way to solve the Rebel's Dilemma, that is, to explain deviations from Olson's General Law of Collective Inaction. Their analysis rests on four assumptions. (1) Individuals are utility maximizers; given the alternative states of their environment, they evaluate the outcomes of their various possible actions. (2) Political demands are typically for a PG; if job discrimination is ended, for example, people can enjoy the principle of diversity regardless of whether they participate in the demonstration. (3) The group of potential sympathizers is very large; there may be thousands of individuals interested in the principles espoused by a dissident group. (4) Large groups have the power to affect government policy; however, each person's individual participation has no discernible impact on the group's success at winning adoption of its policy.

For CA to occur, the Rebel's Dilemma must be solved by revising one or more of these and other assumptions. Thus, one can make the assumptions more realistic or complicated by considering the potential dissident's choice among more than two tactics (e.g., staying home, voting, lobbying, and demonstrating), given more than two expectations about the behavior of others (i.e., the *number* of other participants), and given some uncertainty about the outcome of the actions he or she takes. Most CA theorists, accordingly, have attempted to modify the CA research program by proposing solutions to the free rider problem. To explain why *rational* people might participate in CA, they modify the assumptions behind the basic PG–PD game (Lichbach forthcoming, chap. 2). There are presently more than two dozen distinct solutions to Olson's Problem.

It should now be clear that DA and CA theorists face opposite tasks. Given the ubiquity of grievances, for Gurr (1970) the *problematique* is to explain why people do not rebel. He thus elaborates a set of structural conditions that must be present before anger can be turned into rebellion. Given the ubiquity of free riding, Olson's (1965) *problematique* is to explain why people do rebel. He thus elaborates the selective incentives and federal group solutions to the CA problem.

In sum, students of conflict found the marriage of theories of CA with problems of collective dissent to be a failure, because few CA ideas were actually used and few substantive issues actually studied. This deficiency is ironic because pure theorists of CA have elaborated Olson's basic insight into more than two dozen different solutions to the PG–PD game. The purpose of this book is to remedy this sad state of affairs and bring the richness of the CA research program to bear on conflict studies. The next chapter outlines the approach.